



THE FIGHT FOR AMERICA'S FAMILIES

Exposing the Corruption in Family Courts and CPS.

They took my kids. They tried to silence me. They WON'T.

FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 50

WEST VIRGINIA

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside West Virginia's family courts and child-welfare system.

40

WEST VIRGINIA FAMILIES ON RECORD
· 66 CHILDREN IMPACTED · 25
MONTHS MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF
PARENTING TIME

REPORT GENERATED

MAY 6, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED

23 OF 55

COMPILED BY

MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS · WEST VIRGINIA

A name appears below only after 3 or more independent families have named the same actor in West Virginia. Submitter names, emails, and contact details are never published. Comments below are direct family reports — one per family — with all identifying information removed.

Maggie KuhlATTORNEY / GAL / CHILD REPRESENTATIVE · PUTNAM · **3 FAMILIES**

"Maggie Kuhl works at Putnam County Courthouse multiple times during the week. She is also represented Cara Branham my ex for the majority of the court proceedings over the 11 years and the 22 times that she has sued me for contempt and there's only one twice both financial both because the other Party owes me \$4000 and refuses to pay any of accrued cost on my side of the fence. Maggie Kuhl works at Putnam County Courthouse multiple times during the week. She is also represented Cara Branham my ex for the majority of the court proceedings over the 11 years and the 22 times that she has sued me for contempt and there's only one twice both financial both because the other Party owes me \$4000 and refuses to pay any of accrued cost on my side of the fence. She also has violated professional codes of conduct like that is her main job with lying coming in right before court and filing something knowing that I'm representing myself and don't have time to respond going outside of the quart room with Joseph Hunter to then take my decision making away when I was representing myself so they had a closed-door discussion about who was going to have decision-making without me present, and I'm representing myself. She has tried to embarrass me at my workplace by having somebody come in, and serve me multiple times even though I have my cell phone number that hasn't changed for almost 17 years and stated the first time I was served at my workplace to call me and I will meet them anywhere to get the paperwork. They do not need to come to my employment and try to embarrass me at my employer. They still continue to do so" **PUTNAM COUNTY**

"I have a special needs child. I was always 100% primary parent and that father never went to doc appts or therapy appts. that he never paid for food or diapers or anything. The father never spent anytime with the child. Then later I was told that she has "relations" with the petitioner's counsel. Maggie never opened her mouth in defense. she also said that she had never lost a case to the petitioner's attorney and made a lot of good proposes and then rolled over and did nothing during trial to protect the child. Even when I gave her alot of evidence to us"

"At one point, she went over a year without speaking to the kids, yet continued to write reports and make recommendations."

Public threshold rule: Names are grouped conservatively by normalized spelling, role, and location. Common titles, punctuation, casing, and middle initials collapse together. Close misspellings are not auto-merged without admin review. Only family-direct submissions count toward the public threshold.

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

WEST VIRGINIA AT A GLANCE.

Across 40 West Virginia families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 66 40 of 40 families reported child counts	MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN \$58,300 median across 10 families reporting 3+ categories	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 25 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 47.5% 32.5% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 40	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.6	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 40 of 40	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 23

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so West Virginia families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

03

THE COST OF WEST VIRGINIA FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	25	\$6,500	\$22,861	\$571,516
Lost Wages	15	\$1,000	\$10,549	\$158,230
Other Court Fees	10	\$0	\$402	\$4,020
Therapy / Evaluations	17	\$2,000	\$3,451	\$58,673
Reunification Services	15	\$3	\$1,867	\$28,003
GAL Fees	14	\$0	\$3,772	\$52,801
Asset Loss	15	\$5,000	\$98,347	\$1,475,200
Median Family Burden (10 families reporting 3+ categories)	—	\$58,300	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least \$1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		25	2.1 yrs
Mean months lost		38	3.2 yrs
Total across all families		1,110	92.5 yrs

04 WHO IS REPORTING · WEST VIRGINIA

Most families documenting in West Virginia are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed		21	52%
Case closed: within last 2 years		8	20%
Not provided		5	12%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		4	10%
Not in court but still affected		1	2%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		19	48%
Family Court Only		10	25%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		9	22%
Unknown		2	5%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		12	30%
5 – 10 years		8	20%
3 – 5 years		5	12%
Over 10 years		4	10%
Less than 6 months		4	10%

CUSTODY STATUS

Visitation Only		11	28%
No Contact / Total Loss of Access		9	22%
Adopted Out (Rights Terminated)		9	22%
Children in Foster Care		6	15%
50/50 Joint		2	5%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Mason		4	10%
Putnam		3	8%
Wood		3	8%
Barbour		2	5%
Upshur		2	5%
Harrison		2	5%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		17	42%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		13	32%
Other: (Short answer)		4	10%
High Conflict Divorce		1	2%
Medical CPS (Medical Child Abuse allegations, disagreement with doctors)		1	2%

05 PARENT VOICES — WEST VIRGINIA

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable West Virginia comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.



An abusive narcissist was able to rip my children away from me by claiming parental alienation after years of emotional, mental and legal abuse.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Destroyed my entire family. My now adult children have problems from enduring this trauma. My marriage failed because of this. I lost custody of my youngest 2 children to my ex husband, with the assistance of him paying off CPS workers to take my children with no investigation [...]

— WEST VIRGINIA PARENT · AMANDA

MORE VOICES FROM WEST VIRGINIA

The family court has completely destroyed my family. I have been robbed of the right to motherhood and all access to my children over false allegations and abusive systematic procedures.

— JESSI

Traumatized us my children have been medically neglected and abused since being in state care

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system sealed and silenced us while stripping all of us of our rights and innocence, not just the children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Family court proved that abuse can be rewarded and those who never abuse their kids can be punished. As soon as my children were ordered into the full custody of their father, opposing counsel sent an email offering to return the children if I obtained a “do not prosecute” to [...]

— CRISTY

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



The systems has stole my children's life as my children as me as a good contract mother yrs. They stole our life of church God with my children by assaults retolerations after trying to protect myself and family . Our lives are destroyed by the courts fraud abussive litigations [...]

— INCA

Cps has done nothing but tear my family apart for years. I have severe ptsd and anxiety so badly. My children do too. My youngest child now suffers from an eating disorder. I just want her back home. I will never stop fighting for her.

— CONNIE

Separated and divided the family and alienated me from my kids

— DANIEL

DESTROYED CHILDRENS CHILDHOOD,13 FOSTER HOMES ,AND SEPORATED Boys.DEEPLY HURT WHOLE FAMILY,WE WILL NEVER LOOK AT FAMILY COURT THE SAME THEY ARE SAVAGES!

— GAIL

The system has completely DESTROYED my family. I feel like I have no purpose to live anymore.

— AMBER

The system has destroyed relationships, legacies, holidays, milestones, but it has cost me a beautiful relationship with my sons, one that I had with my father, and he had with his father, and it will affect both of these young men for the rest of their lifetime. I'm not a [...]

— BRANDON

Lied put whatever in reports cussed me n kids n gets by with it

— TAMMY

It ripped my daughters away because my daughter got with a girl at school (a trouble maker) who told her to do this and she could do whatever she wanted. They took my daughters away from me who was my everything. Now I have nothing. I want to give up.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has wrecked my life no doubt but more importantly my children's lives and their futures. These kids are affected for the rest of their lives and will prob never be able to fully trust anyone again. The struggle they've been facing trying to understand why they were [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



They put my son through unnecessary stress

— TRACEY

There was no investigation, only an initial contact with CPS alleging educational neglect, in regards to missing 3rd grade assessment. I explained this was our 3rd grade year and assessment is due by June 30 2026. Heard nothing else from CPS. 3.5 months later sheriff serves me [...]

— MISTI

The system has destroyed my family. They couldn't care less about my daughter. They knew I was unable to fork out all the money I needed to to get proper legal representation.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Ruined my life not only my kids but mine after my mom was killed 25 years ago by my stepdad

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Has literally taken my very life

— RACHEL

Ripped my identity of being a MOTHER and turned me into a ghost to my children when I'm all they ever known! Separated all my children breaking our soul tied bonds! Took a piece a paper of lies to erase DNA .!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They have not only stolen my sense of self but they've robbed me and my husband of creating a bond with our newborn. They have shattered my daughters (6 yr old) trust and emotional health.

— CHELSEA

They have taken my Heart, my soul, my love, my life and stomped it into hell on earth.

— T

Ruined my life health spirit. I am dead inside

— DANIELLE

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



They have traumatized us, villainized us, and caused us an extreme amount of emotional and mental anguish, while putting me over \$40,000 in credit debt. Took away my precious parenting time and my daughters teen years that we will never get back.

— HEATHER

Broken our home, our hearts, our trust in the system. Taken precious time that I will never get back with my child.

— NICOLE

Has treated us unfairly treat us like we're criminals without reading the facts just make stuff up and they believe it they told my 3 grandchildren that we didn't want or love you hem because they fart this is not even close to the truth

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has cost me everything. My child, the innocence of my child. Our bond. My motherhood. A child's childhood. It has cost me my mental health even further, my ability to trust "justice" and "authority". It has cost me my home, finances, a nest egg my deceased father left me [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Torn my family apart. Given me no hope. Cause emotional damage to my son and myself.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has broke a good family and had stole my children and would not listen to them so I am afraid if something really bad does happen to them then they won't say anything cause no one listen to them before and makes me scared for them

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The system has taken over 5% of my childs life with him that I will never get back during a time when his mother needs him the most.

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It completely tore my world apart and made me have no hope in the justice system/government!

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The court system that says God as our witnesses allowed a criminal lawyer defend criminals in family court. The psychological harm and reputation is forever dipped in hell and I'll gladly give up my ticket to upstairs to meet them at its gate in the Gods Court

— KAYLA

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

Neither attorney acknowledged that my son is special needs bc father doesn't want him labeled. son is almost 3 and non verbal. court gave father 50/50 custody and he does not attend doc appts or therapy and cannot communicate with child. child does not get proper hygiene with [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

34 West Virginia parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 34 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — WEST VIRGINIA

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from West Virginia families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

An abusive narcissist was able to rip my children away from me by claiming parental alienation after years of emotional, mental and legal abuse.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The family court has completely destroyed my family. I have been robbed of the right to motherhood and all access to my children over false allegations and abusive systematic procedures.

— JESSI

Destroyed my entire family. My now adult children have problems from enduring this trauma. My marriage failed because of this. I lost custody of my youngest 2 children to my ex husband, with the assistance of him paying off CPS workers to take my children with no investigation or evidence. Now my youngest 2 boys are without their mother during their teenage years.

— AMANDA

Traumatized us my children have been medically neglected and abused since being in state care

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system sealed and silenced us while stripping all of us of our rights and innocence, not just the children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Family court proved that abuse can be rewarded and those who never abuse their kids can be punished. As soon as my children were ordered into the full custody of their father, opposing counsel sent an email offering to return the children if I obtained a “do not prosecute” to spare the father from the fallout of his crimes. Unable to get that, the smear campaign continued and I am still without my children. The theory of parental alienation is being misused and weaponized in true, substantiated abuse cases. I lost complete faith in our legal system.

— CRISTY

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

The systems has stole my children's life as my children as me as a good contract mother yrs. They stole our life of church God with my children by assaults retolerations after trying to protect myself and family . Our lives are destroyed by the courts fraud abussive litigations Satan cruelty retolerations for money .

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— AMBER

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The system has destroyed relationships, legacies, holidays, milestones, but it has cost me a beautiful relationship with my sons, one that I had with my father, and he had with his father, and it will affect both of these young men for the rest of their lifetime. I'm not a perfect man, and I have made mistakes and I have reacted to some situations that I have been put in in not the best way, but I have never jeopardize my son safety I have always thought about the best interest of my son's future, their financial longevity, their success in business and in relationships and family and growth. I've went from a hero to a zero on the sidelines cheering, my son, being a part of every minute to being ripped away like a villain, no arrest, The physical and Dangerman just false allegations, small town good old boy, clubs, and manipulation by a system. That is the biggest Ponzi scheme money making garbage I've ever had the disgust to experience in my 38 years on this earth. This place is where dreams go to die!!

— BRANDON

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— TAMMY

It ripped my daughters away because my daughter got with a girl at school (a trouble maker) who told her to do this and she could do whatever she wanted. They took my daughters away from me who was my everything. Now I have nothing. I want to give up.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has wrecked my life no doubt but more importantly my children's lives and their futures. These kids are affected for the rest of their lives and will prob never be able to fully trust anyone again. The struggle they've been facing trying to understand why they were taken from their loving home and been allowed 0 contact with their mother since has done unimaginable irreversible damage and pain to these innocent babies and their parents. This corrupt system lies everyday to every one of us, starting with them stating that they are "for the kids". They are for no child, they're for their pockets and that is all. Thats the truth and it is horrifying.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They put my son through unnecessary stress

— TRACEY

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

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— MISTI

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has cost me everything. My child, the innocence of my child. Our bond. My motherhood. A child's childhood. It has cost me my mental health even further, my ability to trust "justice" and "authority". It has cost me my home, finances, a nest egg my deceased father left me which was for me and my future children to thrive. My dignity, my spirit, I am a shell of who I once was. It has almost cost me my job due to overwhelm. The court has allowed domestic abuse to thrive, while my entire life has been torn part. My life has been deduced to before this.. and after this.. My child reported sexual abuse, my mental health was targeted, and the abusers go without remorse, they thrive off my dime and have used a scared little girl in their disgusting pawn to further destroy me, while they destroy her. They have taken EVERYTHING from me.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Torn my family apart. Given me no hope. Cause emotional damage to my son and myself.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

It has broke a good family and had stole my children and would not listen to them so I am afraid if something really bad does happen to them then they won't say anything cause no one listen to them before and makes me scared for them

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— KAYLA

Neither attorney acknowledged that my son is specials needs bc father doesnt want him labeled. son is almost 3 and non verbal. court gave father 50/50 custody and he does not attend doc appts or therapy and cannot communicate with child. child does not get proper hygiene with the father and father repeatedly reports to me that child refuses to eat or drink on his time.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

34 full approved West Virginia comments are included in this appendix.

07 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this West Virginia report comes from West Virginia respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in West Virginia — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 40 West Virginia families reporting here are not the universe of West Virginia families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – May 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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